of violence, and there is a limited chance of discovering that the design was a mistake.

In the optimistic view, the engineer in the government is omniscient and cares about the welfare of the people. In the real world, both these assumptions are questionable.

It is very difficult to think about design questions on the scale of society. Human systems reflect the interactions of a large number of sentient persons, and attempts at intervention are plagued by the law of unintended consequences. We may emphasize that social systems involve the interactions of many *people*, and envisioning these complexities requires knowledge of the social sciences and humanities, and not just engineering. Hence, the policymaker can easily be wrong.

In addition, public choice theory reminds us that policymakers are just people, and are likely to pursue their own personal objectives, which may or may not align with welfare of the public.

For these reasons, it is useful to approach system thinking with high scepticism, and use the coercive power of the state in reshaping society only rarely. For most situations, the self-organizing system that is the market economy works better. This reflects a trade-off between the cost of some situations where system design in public policy goes wrong versus the cost of some situation where the self-organizing system gets trapped in the wrong equilibrium.

The self-organizing system works better than state-led design of society when state capacity is high. It is even more attractive when state capacity is low. When state capacity is low, there is a greater chance that state power will be used to impose the wrong designs upon society. There is a greater chance of this power being hijacked to serve an agenda other than public welfare.

Hence, while mature market economies avoid system thinking, we in India should avoid it even more.